

U of A professor says she was dismissed over views that biological sex trumps transgender identity for policy decisions

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University of Alberta associate professor Kathleen Lowrey was dismissed as associate chair of undergraduate studies in the department of anthropology in March. Lowrey says she believes she was dismissed over her critical views of gender. / jpg

A University of Alberta associate professor says she was dismissed from an administrative role over her views that transgender identity doesn't trump biological sex for policy decisions.

Kathleen Lowrey, an associate professor of anthropology, took on the additional role of associate chair of undergraduate programs for the department at the start of the 2019-20 school year. On March 24, she received a letter from the Faculty of Arts dean Lesley Cormack informing her the three-year term would end July 1.

Lowrey, who describes herself as a gender-critical feminist, said Saturday she was fired because of her views.

"People should be able to express their gender in whatever manner they wish (but) I don't agree with biological sex being irrelevant," she said. "I think treating biological sex as irrelevant has some really serious policy implications. As an example, housing trans-identified men in women's prisons is not fair to women prisoners and I think it puts women at risk."

In the letter, Cormack said Lowrey was no longer "effective" in the administrative role and "it is not in the best interests of the students or the university for you (Lowrey) to carry on."

The letter doesn't specify how the university came to this conclusion.

Fwd: Conclusion of Associate Chair appointment

Dear Kathleen,

I am writing to inform you that your appointment to the position of Associate Chair, Undergraduate Studies in the Department of Anthropology will conclude effective July 1, 2020. You are unfortunately not able to be as effective in this administrative role as the Department and Faculty require, and it is not in the best interests of the students or the University for you to carry on. This of course has no connection to or bearing upon your role, rights and entitlements an academic staff member, which all continue.

Although they would typically cease, I am willing to allow you to continue with your teaching release for 2020/21 and convert your \$3500 annual stipend to a small research grant for 2020/21, on the condition that you complete the remainder of your time in the position effectively and in accordance with instructions. Thank you for your time in the role, and I look forward to your assistance with a smooth transition.

Sincerely,
Lesley

Lesley Cormack
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An email by Faculty of Arts dean Lesley Cormack to associate professor Kathleen Lowrey appears to show the latter being dismissed from her role as associate chair of undergraduate programs on March 24. KATHLEEN LOWREY/SUPPLIED

Hallie Brodie, issues and strategic communications manager with the university, said in an email Sunday she could not comment on the status of Lowrey's administrative appointment because of privacy reasons but Lowrey remains an associate professor at the school.

Lowrey said she has made her views public, including publishing an article on the website Feminist Current, posting signs on her office door and letting her class know at the start of January that she would be touching on the subject through materials written by gender-critical feminists.

"I said on the first day of class we're going to read material in this class that are currently out of fashion in academia," she said. "You certainly don't have to agree with me. Since this is a university, I think it's important to be exposed to — this is important literature they should be aware of."

Lowrey said she met with both Cormack and her department chair before the letter was sent out but neither provided specific details other than saying students felt uncomfortable.

"If you've done something bad to students you're supposed to have a hearing about it so you can answer what the charges are," she said. "If I've done

something bad they should be able to say what it is. Or it is about my views? Which in that case that's not so good because that's really a violation of academic freedom."

Lowrey, who has been with the university since 2005, said the faculty association has filed a grievance. She said she will be able to continue working as a teacher and researcher at the university but worries what this means for others who share her views.

"The university has said it's perfectly OK to fire people for doubting that men can get pregnant, for doubting lesbians can have penises," she said. "The implications are very dangerous because this is a live issue in our contemporary Canadian democracy."

Joel Agarwal, president for the U of A student's union, said they firmly support an inclusive learning space for all students, including the LGBTQ+ community.

"As this is a Human Resources matter between Dr. Lowrey and the University, subject to the staff association's collective agreement, we don't have the information to make any further comments," said Agarwal.

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